



SAFE AND SOUND: Indian pangolin; (inset) Pattnaik

Saving Private Pangolin

Nandankanan zoological park has achieved a first in the world by breeding a rare reclusive mammal

■ **By Farzand Ahmed**

Every morning Ajit Kumar Pattnaik, 45, goes into one of the six enclosures in the middle of the Nandankanan Zoological Park and touches a scaly mammal. He then closely examines the quantity and quality of termites left as the mammal's food. The mammal, known as Indian pangolin, curls up as if in self-defence and then moves back into the burrow.

Pattnaik, director of the park on the outskirts of Bhubaneswar and also the man credited with saving the Chilika lagoon, smiles and says proudly, "Nandankanan is the only zoo in India known for successful rearing of pangolin in captivity." There are, to date, nine in the park.

The Indian Pangolin (*Manis Crassicaudata*) is listed as near-threatened by the International Union for the Conservation of Nature and Natural Resources. Though there has been no survey or census on the number of Indian Pangolin, authorities were alarmed about the scale of destruction. Pattnaik says four gunny bags of pangolin scales were seized in the state capital.

Rearing the 65-cm long mammal, weighing 8 kg and having peculiar food and living habits, in captivity was a real challenge. However, Pattnaik and his team made a detailed



study of the pangolin's food and living habits before venturing forth. Standardising the food for the pangolin was an achievement which ensured that the rare mammal could be bred in captivity. Nandankanan recorded 14 births, reproductive health being a good indicator of the overall health status of a species in captivity. The next challenge before the zoo was the very high mortality of the zoo-born young

pangolin—death within few days of birth. In two cases they survived for more than one year.

The pangolins, whose scales are made of Keratin (the same substance as the human fingernail), are housed in a special enclosure. Pregnant females tend to dig the floor with their strong claws before delivering their offspring. In one instance, a pregnant pangolin vanished into a deep burrow dug by her—up to 6m deep, inside one corner of the enclosure. Surprisingly, she reappeared after a week with a baby mounted on her tail.

This led Pattnaik to have burrows dug inside the enclosures and pile up termites for the mammal's food as a means of making expectant mothers comfortable. The Central Zoo Authority has sanctioned a conservation breeding programme for its implementation at Nandankanan where breeding of pangolin is first of its kind in the world. ■